

INTRODUCTION

Psychological Reactance Theory: An Introduction and Overview

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There has been a recent surge in psychological reactance theory (PRT) scholarship. After nearly 60 years, the theory still draws attention and guides useful research. Herein, we introduce a special issue dedicated to new empirical studies and theoretical advances. We begin by describing PRT's core concepts and assumptions, followed by a brief overview of scholarship on PRT, which is organized in five overlapping waves. Interspersed with our description of these waves, we briefly summarize the nine articles that comprise this volume. These works represent contributions from four of the main waves of PRT scholarship—clinical psychology, communication, measurement, and motivation.

Keywords: psychological reactance, freedom restriction, motivation

Initially proposed nearly 60 years ago, psychological reactance theory (PRT; J. W. Brehm, 1966) describes how people respond to threats to, or elimination of, valued freedoms. At its core, PRT is a motivational framework that explains the ways in which freedom threats prompt a suite of behavioral (e.g., boomerang effects; J. W. Brehm, 1966), subjective (e.g., source derogation; Rains, 2013), and physiological responses (e.g., skin conductance) aimed at regaining lost freedom (for review, see Rosenberg & Siegel, 2018). Over the years, PRT has received generally stalwart empirical support (S. S. Brehm & Brehm, 1981; Reynolds-Tylus, 2019; Rosenberg & Siegel, 2018) and catalyzed research in a variety of areas (e.g., clinical psychology; Beutler et al., 2002; Shoham et al., 2004). Unlike some theories that garner decreasing empirical attention over time, there has been a notable uptick in PRT scholarship—particularly following COVID-19 pandemic-related restrictions (e.g., vaccine and mask mandates; Soveri et al., 2024). This increased interest in reactance motivated us to produce this special issue, which is devoted to the breadth of PRT's application, primarily focusing on new theoretical developments and recent findings.

Key Constructs and Assumptions of PRT

Steeped in the cognitive consistency tradition (for review, see Proulx et al., 2012), PRT (J. W. Brehm, 1966) hinges

on the assumption that people have a set of highly valued free behaviors—actions, thoughts, or feelings that they perceive to have the freedom and ability to enact or experience. Threats to, or elimination of, people's ability to engage in one of these free behaviors arouse a motivational state aimed at restoring lost freedom (i.e., psychological reactance). J. W. Brehm (1966) suggests that holding free behaviors is evolutionarily advantageous in that it allows people to choose the best course of action or belief given their current circumstances. Reactance is a motivational state; it is not inherently frustrating or negative, but instead drives people to regain freedom. Although people do not always desire freedom, its loss is motivationally arousing (J. W. Brehm, 1966). Reactance is often operationalized as a mix of anger and negative cognitions (Dillard & Shen, 2005; Quick, 2012; Rains, 2013) that prompts several specific outcomes aimed at freedom restoration, including those that are behavioral (e.g., boomerang effects; J. W. Brehm, 1966), subjective (e.g., source derogation; Rains, 2013), and physiological (e.g., increased heart rate).

Early support for PRT's core contentions was reliable (e.g., Mazis et al., 1973; Wicklund & Brehm, 1968) and prompted S. S. Brehm and Brehm (1981) to publish a book reviewing evidence for PRT to that point and, notably, outlining a wide range of future directions for the framework. Rosenberg and Siegel (2018) provided an updated review of PRT scholarship that grouped this work into five overlapping waves—Wave 1: Theory proposal and testing; Wave 2: Contributions from clinical psychology; Wave 3: Contributions from communication research; Wave 4: Measuring reactance; and Wave 5: Return to motivation.

Research in this volume highlights contributions from four of the five primary waves of PRT scholarship. We intentionally overemphasize recent scholarship on motivation to align with the journal's readership and, perhaps more importantly, with the current direction of the field (e.g., Rosenberg & Siegel, 2023). In what follows, we briefly summarize notable contributions from each wave of PRT scholarship and the attendant contributions from this special issue.

Editor's Note. This is an introduction to the special issue "Advances in Reactance Theory and Research: Do Not Read This Special Issue." Please see the Table of Contents here: <https://psycnet.apa.org/journals/mot/11/2/>. —GHEG and RAW

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Wave 1: Theory Proposal and Testing

Early PRT research tested its primary contention: when people's free behaviors are threatened or eliminated, they experience psychological reactance, which motivates them to regain their lost freedom (J. W. Brehm, 1966). These early studies showed that free behaviors are subjective (e.g., Wicklund & Brehm, 1968) and that reactance can be aroused by freedom elimination (e.g., outright bans; Mazis et al., 1973) or freedom threat (i.e., anything that impedes but does not eliminate, freedom—like a social influence attempt; J. W. Brehm, 1966). In addition, this work showed that higher magnitude threats induce more reactance than threats of a lower magnitude (e.g., Organ, 1974), and perceiving that a threatening agent is explicitly attempting to persuade people can induce reactance (e.g., Jones & Brehm, 1970). J. W. Brehm's (1966) theorizing and these early studies indicated that implied threats (Andreoli et al., 1974) directed at other people can also arouse reactance (e.g., Pallak & Heller, 1971).

Foundational work supported several avenues through which people could restore their freedom once reactance is aroused. J. W. Brehm (1966) focused on boomerang effects, whereby people engage in restricted behavior. Other early research, much of which included Brehm, examined other ways people can restore lost freedom, including the increased desire for, and attractiveness of, a threatened behavior (e.g., J. W. Brehm & Rozen, 1971) and hostility toward the source of the threat (e.g., Nezlek & Brehm, 1975). Laying the foundation for later work, scholars in this period also began considering moderators of reactance effects, including personality traits (e.g., locus of control; Rotter, 1966) and an inability to regain freedom (i.e., learned helplessness; Wortman & Brehm, 1975).

Wave 2: Contributions From Clinical Psychology

S. S. Brehm and Brehm's (1981) review and restatement of PRT included a call for broader application of the framework, which catalyzed research in various domains. Of note, the authors argued that psychological reactance as a construct had considerable potential in clinical psychology (for a discussion see S. S. Brehm, 1976). This call led to two related developments—first, clinical psychologists began reconceptualizing reactance as a trait instead of only a momentary motivational state (for review see Shoham et al., 2004). As Kelly and Nauta (1997) stated, trait reactance is the “consistent tendency to perceive and react to situations as if one's freedoms were being threatened” (p. 1124). Second, conceiving of reactance as a trait resulted in several novel approaches to clinical treatment. Some clinicians considered reactance as a moderator of therapeutic success, where clients' perceptions that therapists threatened their freedom could lead them to become resistant to treatment (e.g., Tracey et al., 1989). Another approach sought to avoid resistance by offering clients a choice in treatment (e.g., Beutler, 1979), while a third considered the importance of understanding clients' levels of trait reactance to properly tailor treatment (e.g., lots of choices for those high in trait reactance; Dowd & Seibel, 1990).

In the current volume, De Las Cuevas and de Leon (2025) systematically review psychological reactance research for clinical practice with psychiatric patients. The authors argue that, particularly given the severity of many psychiatric patients' diagnoses and limited treatment options, treatment is often perceived as a threat to their autonomy. The authors review 22 studies applying reactance to this population. Building on this literature, the authors present a model

illustrating how awareness of psychological reactance can reduce potential harms and increase benefits for clinicians and patients. The authors provide tips on practical interventions for clinicians seeking to use psychological reactance research with psychiatric patients.

Wave 3: Contributions From Communication Research

As Wave 2 took off, scholars in communication research (e.g., Bensley & Wu, 1991; Buller et al., 1998) began to explore how PRT could explain the phenomena in their field (for reviews, see Quick, 2013; Reynolds-Tylus, 2019). Two key lines of work emerged from this ongoing and robust scholarship. First, communication researchers created the most utilized paradigm for experimentally assessing reactance: embedded freedom-restricting phrases in persuasive messages (e.g., Miller et al., 2007). The primary finding from this paradigm was that messages with high-controlling language aroused greater reactance than those that use low-controlling or autonomy-supportive language (for review, see Staunton et al., 2022). In turn, high-controlling language messages tended to be less persuasive—and even resulted in boomerang effects—when compared to low-controlling language messages (for review see Grandpre et al., 2003).

Given the reliability of this result, research turned to examining message factors that could reduce reactance arousal (for review, see Quick et al., 2013). Although the list of reactance-reducing message techniques continues to grow, current evidence supports the use of restoration postscripts (i.e., reminding recipients of their freedom to choose; Bessarabova et al., 2013), message novelty (e.g., Kang et al., 2006) and sensation value (e.g., Quick, 2013), narrative (e.g., Moyer-Gusé & Nabi, 2010), empathy (e.g., Shen, 2010), and inoculation (i.e., forewarning of persuasive intent; Richards et al., 2017). In addition, other research used message-induced reactance for good by presenting unfavorable behavior as a threat to message targets' freedom. Using this approach made it so that reactance against a message resulted in avoiding an undesirable behavior and, hopefully, engaging in the opposite—a desirable behavior (e.g., not smoking indoors, Quick et al., 2009). Most recently, Falco and Rosenberg (2025) outlined approaches for minimizing reactance in messages targeting people with depression.

The current volume contains two articles on Wave 3. In the first of these papers, Zhou et al. (2025) examine reactance in the context of interpersonal advice giving to provide two novel contributions to the literature. These authors directly compare multiple models of the reactance process, showing that although sometimes confused in the literature (for review, see Ratcliff, 2021), the perceived threat is an antecedent of reactance—not one of its components or outcomes. Zhou et al. (2025) report that reactance to advice seekers is greatest when their requests are inexplicit and are coupled with controllable attributions (i.e., seekers' problems are of their own doing).

Quick et al. (2025) conduct a classic reactance experiment on a relatively novel concept: legislation advocating the legalization of psilocybin for medical use. Counter to expectations and most of the reactance literature, the authors find that more controlling messages do not predict perceptions of freedom threats. The authors suggest that their messages fail to arouse reactance for two possible and equally compelling reasons. Quick and colleagues note that because using psilocybin, or supporting its use, is likely not established free behaviors, people do not perceive the messages as threatening. The authors also argue that because psilocybin legalization is still a relatively controversial and uncertain topic, participants could feel uncertain—and that can ameliorate the effects of controlling language.

Wave 4: Measuring Reactance

As communication research based on PRT expanded, many of these same scholars (e.g., Dillard & Shen, 2005) began to address one of the principal criticisms of PRT—that state psychological reactance is immeasurable (J. W. Brehm, 1966; S. S. Brehm & Brehm, 1981). Early PRT research rarely measured reactance directly, instead assessing its outcomes (e.g., boomerang effects, Worchel & Brehm, 1970); in the past 20 years, a renewed focus on directly measuring the construct has emerged (for review see Rosenberg & Siegel, 2018). Researchers assessing trait reactance primarily use three scales: The Questionnaire for Measuring Psychological Reactance (Merz, 1983), the Therapeutic Reactance Scale (Dowd et al., 1991), and the Hong Psychological Reactance Scale (Hong & Page, 1989).

Similarly, three validated self-report measures of state reactance were put forth in the literature: the widely used intertwined model (Dillard & Shen, 2005) as well as two more recent scales, the Salzburg State Reactance Scale (Sittenthaler et al., 2015) and the Reactance to Health Warnings Scale (Hall et al., 2016). A measure validation (Dillard & Shen, 2005), a comparison of measures (Quick, 2012), and a meta-analysis (Rains, 2013) supported the intertwined model, which conceives of reactance as an amalgam of anger and negative cognitions. Recent work on measuring reactance physiologically has also emerged.

Two papers in the current special issue are relevant to Wave 4. As noted earlier, reactance is typically considered an amalgam of anger and negative cognitions. Clayton et al. (2025) expand the measurement repertoire of researchers seeking to assess the cognitive aspects of reactance beyond just negative cognitions. To do so, the authors examine three additional types of cognitive resistance to persuasive messages (i.e., avoiding, contesting, and empowering) combined with anger to create a novel measure of reactance. The authors find that in addition to negative cognitions, two other cognitive features of reactance (i.e., source derogating and attitude bolstering) are related to anger and predict reactance outcomes (e.g., behavioral intentions).

Mühlberger et al. (2025) present a relatively rare study to better understand the physiological underpinnings of psychological reactance. With the goal of disentangling reactance from anger, participants in this study read freedom-threatening, anger-inducing, or neutral scenarios and measured their brain activity using functional magnetic resonance imaging. The findings indicate that participants asked to imagine a freedom-threatening scenario exhibited similar brain activation to those found in studies on theory of mind, mental states, and mentalizing. Put another way, the data indicate that patterns of brain activation for participants in the freedom threat condition are likely not due to the affective component of reactance (i.e., anger), indicating that reactance may have a distinct pattern in the brain.

Wave 5: Return to Motivation

J. W. Brehm (1966) conceived of reactance as a distinctly motivational construct: “reactance is defined *not* simply as an unpleasant tension...but rather a motivational state with a specific direction, namely, the recovery of freedom” (p. 11, *italics original*). Although Brehm’s conception of reactance was clear, motivation did not play a central role in most PRT research until Miron and

Brehm (2006) suggested that it belonged alongside other theories that are motivational in nature (e.g., motivation intensity theory; J. W. Brehm & Self, 1989). This recommendation helped catalyze several similar perspectives (e.g., Wright et al., 2015) and sections specifically about reactance’s motivational properties in two reviews (Rosenberg & Siegel, 2018; Steindl et al., 2015). Additionally, Leander et al. (2016) grouped PRT with other motivational frameworks, including self-determination theory (Deci & Ryan, 2000).

Rosenberg and Siegel (2018) proposed three specific areas for continued investigation of the motivational roots of PRT. First, these authors argued that, in addition to personality traits (e.g., locus of control; Rotter, 1966) and message features (e.g., empathy; Shen, 2010), other factors likely moderate people’s reactions to freedom threats (e.g., uncertainty; Rosenberg & Siegel, 2023). Second, Rosenberg and Siegel (2018) noted that along with threats to and elimination of freedom, it is likely that other experiences (e.g., stereotyping; Kray et al., 2001) lead to reactance and its consequent desire to regain freedom (for similar theorizing, see Miron & Brehm, 2006). Third, the authors argued that because reactance is a motivational state, it is likely accompanied by a suite of goal-directed behavioral and cognitive responses (for similar discussions, see Hart, 2014; Proulx, 2012).

This special issue features four articles that align with this wave of PRT research. Adam-Troain and Bélanger (2025) propose that “the supreme art of persuasion is to sway the recipient without provoking reactance.” This article puts forth uncertainty as a motivational tool for minimizing the likelihood of inciting reactance. Adam-Troain and Bélanger (2025) suggest an uncertainty-dissuasion model, which provides three pathways for reducing the possibility of reactance. The model’s first pathway involves infusing doubt into the certainty with which people hold beliefs or attitudes. The second pathway involves causing uncertainty regarding message receivers’ negative assessments of a message or threat. The third path for reducing reactance and its consequences involves leading message receivers to reappraise their anger. Altogether, this model offers a novel means for avoiding reactance and fertile paths for future research.

Jin et al. (2025) focus on trait reactance and propose it as a cause of antiegalitarian beliefs. The authors provide a valuable review of trait reactance, followed by two proposed mechanisms for why higher levels of trait reactance can lead to antiegalitarianism. Jin and colleagues first explain how social discourse about the problematic nature of inequality could lead people with high levels of trait reactance to believe that society is threatening their freedom to think for themselves. The second mechanism involves people with high levels of trait reactance valuing inequality’s psychological benefits. Jin and colleagues conducted a meta-analysis of 18 separate studies that offer empirical support for their theorizing.

Schumpe and Leander (2025) answer the call for additional theorizing on the motivational processes underlying reactance phenomena. The authors, guided by goal systems theory (GST; Kruglanski et al., 2015), offer unique insight into PRT. Schumpe and Leander tap GST to provide an explanatory mechanism for PRT’s prediction that a choice becomes more attractive after the option becomes threatened or eliminated (e.g., J. W. Brehm & Sensenig, 1966). The authors make a compelling argument for the complementary nature of GST and PRT, describing several novel hypotheses derived by bringing the theories together and highlighting how motivational process theories can maximize scholars’ understanding of psychological reactance.

Siegel and Rosenberg (2025)¹ propose a classic innovation by dusting off Wicklund's (1974) hydraulic principle, which drew inspiration from Hull's (1943) drive reduction theory. Wicklund's (1974) hydraulic principle suggests that if people receive a freedom threat shortly after receiving a prior freedom threat, and the reactance from the initial threat has not dissipated, reactance from the first threat would amplify the reactance from the second. Wicklund (1974) and S. S. Brehm and Brehm (1981) offer secondary data supporting the phenomena, but a direct test of the hydraulic principle was rare. Siegel and Rosenberg (2025) rename the occurrence as the reactive spiral and propose one change from S. S. Brehm and Brehm's (1981) theorizing: the two threats do not need to be connected for the reactance amplification to occur. Although the sample size is limited, this empirical investigation offers preliminary experimental evidence for the reactive spiral.

Conclusion

This special issue contains a series of articles that address a range of psychological reactance topics. To ensure a broad representation of current scholarship in the field, we intentionally invited contributions from scholars representing Wave 2: Clinical Psychology, Wave 3: Communication, Wave 4: Measurement, and Wave 5: Motivation. These researchers represent a variety of backgrounds (e.g., social psychologists, clinical psychologists, communication scholars) and career stages. The findings of these diverse scholars that appear in this special issue include novel empirical (e.g., Mühlberger et al., 2025; Siegel & Rosenberg, 2025) and theoretical (e.g., Adam-Troain & Bélanger, 2025; Zhou et al., 2025) contributions to the literature. The impressive work in this volume further highlights the utility of PRT in explaining behavior in a variety of domains. As Lewin (1943, 1952) famously said, "There is nothing more practical than a good theory" (p. 169)—a description that surely applies to PRT nearly 60 years after its inception.

¹ The editors in chief of *Motivation Science*, Rex A. Wright and Guido Gendolla, served as action editors on Siegel and Rosenberg (2025).

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